to Gulbarga from the expedition against Vijayanagar, he was assassinated and the nephew of the conspirator, Daud, the uncle of Muhammad, was enthroned in 1378 as Muhammad II. Muhammad II's reign was peaceful, and the sultan spent much of his time building his court as a centre of culture and learning.

There were constant wars between the Bahmani and Vijayanagar rulers over the fertile Tungabhadra–Krishna region. The threat also came from the north, especially from Malwa and Gujarat. The noteworthy ruler after eight and a half decades (1377 to 1463) was Muhammad III (1463–1482). Muhammad III reigned for 19 years. For most of these years, the lieutenant of the kingdom was Mahmud Gawan, the most notable personality of the time.

Eight ministers of the Bahmani state:
1. Vakil-us-saltana or lieutenant of the kingdom, who was the immediate subordinate authority of the sovereign. 2. Peshwa who was associated with the lieutenant of the kingdom; 3. Waziri-kull who supervised the work of all other ministers; 4. Amir-i-jumla, minister of finance; 5. Nazir, assistant minister for finance; 6. Wasir-i-ashraf, minister of foreign affairs; 7. Kotwal or chief of police and city magistrate in the capital; and 8. Sadr-i-jahan or chief justice and minister of religious affairs and endowments.

Mahmud Gawan

A Persian by birth, Mahmud Gawan was well-versed in Islamic theory, Persian and Mathematics. He was also a poet and a prose writer. The Bahmani king Ala-ud-din Hasan Bahman Shah greatly impressed by his wisdom and military genius, recruited him. He served with great distinction as the Prime Minister under Muhammad III and contributed extensively to the development of the Bahmani kingdom.

Gawan was known for his military campaigns as well as administrative reforms. He used Persian chemists to teach the Bahmani army about the preparation and the use of gunpowder. In his war against the Vijayanagar kings in Belgaum, he used gunpowder. In order to tighten the administration and to curb the power of provincial governors, who often functioned as virtual kings, Gawan divided the existing four provinces of the Bahmani Sultanate into eight provinces so as to limit the area under the rule of each governor and to make the provincial administration more manageable.

He also placed some districts in the provinces directly under the central administration. Gawan sought to curtail the military powers of the governors by allowing them to occupy only one fort in their territory. The sultan kept the other forts under his direct control. The royal officers who were given land assignments as pay were made accountable to the sultan for their income and expenditure.

The administrative reforms introduced by Gawan improved the efficiency of the government, but curtailed the powers of the provincial chiefs, who were mostly *Deccanis*. So the already existing rivalry among nobles such as Deccanis and *Pradesis* (foreigners) further intensified and conflicts broke out.

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